Every Bitter Thing Is Sweet

Balsamic Thai Chili Brussels Sprouts



> "The full soul loathes a honeycomb; but to the hungry soul every bitter thing is sweet." Mishlei 27:7, The Word of יהוה

Serves 4 · **Time** about 35–40 minutes · **Oven** 450°F

Sprouts

1 pound small fresh Brussels sprouts, halved through the stem

2 tablespoons olive oil

¼ teaspoon fine salt, plus more to taste

¼ teaspoon black pepper

Beef bacon

4 ounces beef bacon, cut into ½-inch pieces

Balsamic Thai chili glaze

3 tablespoons Thai sweet chili sauce, not plain chili paste

2 tablespoons balsamic vinegar

1 tablespoon balsamic glaze

¼ teaspoon garlic powder

To finish

¼ cup finely grated Parmesan, plus a little more for serving

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Before you start

1. Set a rack in the middle of the oven and heat it to **450°F**.
2. Rinse the sprouts and dry them thoroughly — dry sprouts brown, wet ones steam. Trim the dry stem ends without cutting so far that the leaves fall away.
3. Halve the sprouts through the stem. Quarter any unusually large ones so the pieces match in size.

Cook the beef bacon

4. Drain any liquid from the package and pat the bacon dry (do not rinse). Put the pieces in a cold skillet and set the burner to medium.
5. Cook, stirring often, until cooked through with crisp edges, following the package directions. Move to a paper-towel-lined plate.
6. Reserve 1 tablespoon of the rendered fat if you'd like to use it in place of some of the olive oil.

Roast the sprouts

7. Toss the sprouts with the olive oil (or oil plus reserved bacon fat), salt, and pepper until thinly, evenly coated.
8. Arrange them **cut-side down** on the unlined sheet with space between pieces. Use two pans if they're crowded.
9. Roast 15 minutes, then check the undersides with a spatula. Small sprouts may be ready at 12 minutes.
10. If needed, roast 3–8 minutes more until deeply browned. Use oven mitts with the hot pan.

Glaze and finish

11. While the sprouts roast, whisk the sweet chili sauce, balsamic vinegar, balsamic glaze, garlic powder, and pepper flakes (if using) in a small saucepan.
12. Warm over **medium-low**, stirring, until steaming and lightly coating a spoon. Don't let it boil hard — the sugars scorch fast.
13. Move the hot sprouts to a large heat-safe bowl. Toss with half the glaze, then add more a spoonful at a time until glossy but not puddled. You may not need it all.
14. Fold in the crisp beef bacon, transfer to a serving dish, shower with Parmesan, and serve right away.

Source: Inspired by the Balsamic Thai Chili Brussels sprouts at Good Charlie's on FM 1488 — our copycat test version, not the restaurant's recipe.